

● WORKSHEET · ICP · POSITIONING · MESSAGING

ICP and *Positioning* Worksheet

Most messaging problems are positioning problems, and most positioning problems are ICP problems. Work through these pages in order: who exactly you serve, what they would use instead, what only you do, and how to say it so a buyer repeats it.

BEFORE YOU START

1. Pull your 10 best customers or design partners: fastest to close, quickest to value, most likely to refer. If you are pre-revenue, use your most engaged pilots.
2. Have notes from at least 5 buyer conversations open. You are writing down what you heard, not what you hope.
3. Do the ICP pages alone first, then compare with your co-founder. The disagreements are the work.

BEST FOR

Founders, first marketers and PR teams writing a message house

TIME

2 to 3 hours, ideally across two sessions

OUTPUT

One ICP, one positioning statement, one messaging hierarchy

PART 1 Ideal customer profile**FIRMOGRAPHICS**

ATTRIBUTE	BEST-FIT CUSTOMERS LOOK LIKE	EVIDENCE (WHICH CUSTOMERS)
Industry / vertical		
Company size (staff or revenue)		
Stage or maturity		
Geography and language		
Tech stack or chain / ecosystem		
Regulatory context		
Budget owner and typical deal size		

TRIGGER EVENTS**WHY NOW**

What happened right before your best customers started looking? (New funding, a hack or audit finding, a new regulation, a hire, a failed vendor, a platform migration, a board mandate on AI.)

PAINS, IN THEIR WORDS

Exact phrases from calls. Note the cost of each pain: hours, money, risk, reputation.

BUYING COMMITTEE

ROLE	TYPICAL TITLE	WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT	WHAT MAKES THEM SAY NO	CONTENT THEY NEED
Economic buyer Signs				
Champion Pushes internally				
User Lives in the product				
Technical evaluator Security, engineering, data				
Blocker Legal, procurement, compliance				

DISQUALIFIERS

SAY NO

Signals that a prospect will churn, stall or cost more than they pay. (Too small to feel the pain, needs on-prem you do not offer, buying only for the logo, no internal owner.)

WHERE THEY GATHER

Publications, newsletters, podcasts, communities, events, people they follow. This becomes your channel and media list.

YOUR ICP IN ONE SENTENCE

[Company type] with [size/stage] that just [trigger event], where [buyer title] is responsible for [outcome].

PART 2

Positioning canvas

Work left to right. Each box depends on the one before it. Positioning is a choice of context that makes your strengths obvious, not a slogan.

1 · COMPETITIVE ALTERNATIVES

What would customers do if you did not exist? Include doing nothing, spreadsheets, in-house builds, generic AI tools, agencies.

2 · UNIQUE CAPABILITIES

What you have that the alternatives do not. Features, data, team expertise, integrations, audits, a business model. Be literal.

3 · VALUE

For each capability: so what? The outcome a customer gets, ideally measurable. "Faster audits" is weak; "ship upgrades without a two-week review queue" is value.

4 · TARGET CUSTOMERS

Who cares most about that value? This should match or sharpen Part 1.

5 · MARKET CATEGORY

The frame that makes your value obvious. Use an existing category plus a qualifier unless you can fund category education.

6 · RELEVANT TRENDS**OPTIONAL**

Trends that make this matter now. Use carefully; trends date quickly and every competitor can claim them.

PART 3

Positioning statement

An internal document, not a tagline. If you can fill every blank with something specific and a customer would nod, you are positioned.

For _____ TARGET CUSTOMER
 who _____ TRIGGER / PROBLEM,
 _____ PRODUCT is a _____ CATEGORY
 that _____ KEY VALUE.
 Unlike _____ MAIN ALTERNATIVE,
 we _____ UNIQUE CAPABILITY + PROOF.

Test it. Read it to 5 people in your ICP. Ask them to describe what you do back to you. If their words differ from yours, use theirs. If they compare you to something you did not list as an alternative, add it and redo the canvas.

PART 4

Messaging hierarchy

CORE CLAIM**ONE SENTENCE**

The one thing you want every buyer, journalist and AI assistant to repeat about you.

PILLAR 1

Value theme

Proof (metric, customer, audit, demo)

PILLAR 2

Value theme

Proof (metric, customer, audit, demo)

PILLAR 3

Value theme

Proof (metric, customer, audit, demo)

WORDS WE USE

WORDS WE AVOID

TOP OBJECTION + ANSWER

● NEXT STEP

Want a senior operator *on your launch?*

Templates get you organised. Coverage, citations and pipeline come from judgement: which angle a journalist will actually take, which channel deserves the next dollar, and what to cut.

Book a 30-minute teardown. Bring your launch plan, your positioning or your last campaign and leave with a prioritised list of fixes.

Book a 30-minute teardown: shilikajain.com/contact

Six years

PR and go-to-market for Web3, AI and cybersecurity founders.

50+ protocols

Launches, funding rounds and token events supported.

Tier-1 outlets

Forbes, CoinDesk, Cointelegraph, Decrypt, The Block, Blockworks, AI Magazine.

Prefer to self-serve first? Try the free interactive planners, budget calculator and checklist at shilikajain.com/tools. More downloads live at shilikajain.com/resources.

Engagements: fractional PR retainer \$5K to \$12K per month. Launch sprint \$15K to \$40K.